Practice Letter: A renewed Visegrad Four's limits

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Practice Letter

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A revived Visegrad Four will face familiar constraints

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Dear Clients,

The arrival of Peter Magyar this year as Hungary's new prime minister—a political earthquake for the country—has created expectations of a revitalized Visegrad Four (V4). Stronger regional cooperation is a central pillar of Magyar's foreign policy ambitions. His first official trip as prime minister was to visit his like-minded counterpart in Poland, Prime Minister Donald Tusk, who clearly had clashed with Viktor Orban. The trip didn't go as planned, with some diplomatic mishaps and, I am told, confusion caused by coordination failures. Regardless, we could all feel the excitement in the air.

The two leaders are staunch supporters of the EU project, even if Magyar is slightly more pragmatic than his Polish counterpart. The Hungarians see the future of a reinvigorated V4 as resting on a renewed Polish-Hungarian axis. Both leaders are clearly working toward that goal through close cooperation and new bilateral projects.

However, Tusk faces reelection in 2027. Though he is currently the front-runner, forming a government will be difficult (see note: Division on the right positions Tusk for likely 2027 victory). His current coalition partners are polling poorly, while the far right continues to gain ground. As a result, Tusk will very likely prioritize domestic politics through much of 2027, which could weaken the long-awaited Hungarian-Polish axis.

Czechia and Slovakia will be more cooperative than previously thought

Czech Prime Minister Andrej Babis and Robert Fico, prime minister of Slovakia, were natural allies of Orban. Nonetheless, the outlook for relations with the other two members of the V4 may be better than it first appears.

Babis sits with Fidesz in the Patriots for Europe group in the European Parliament, but he is too pragmatic to ignore the benefits of an ascendant Magyar, especially at the European Council. Babis wants influence over the next multiannual financial framework (MFF) to make sure Czechia continues to receive EU funding. Coordinating with Magyar can bolster that effort.

Fico was not only an ally of Orban, but also a friend of the former Hungarian leader. He is also less pragmatic and strategic than his Czech counterpart. In that sense, Fico is the weakest link in the V4. Even so, he appears open to working with Magyar and shares his optimism about reviving the grouping after a long period of inactivity.

Questions remain about the V4's purpose and direction

So far, leaders seem hopeful about a revitalized V4. But questions remain: What would its agenda be, and what could it realistically deliver?

The V4 is an informal arrangement among the leaders of the four countries. When they are aligned, cooperation thrives, and when they are not—see the Orban-Tusk deadlock—even regular high-level meetings produce little or get canceled.

To be clear, the V4 is more than a forum for meetings among prime ministers and presidents. Ministers cooperate regularly, and ministries and their departments also coordinate with one another. The Visegrad Fund and access to EU funding add a practical dimension. They support regional and cross-border projects and help the four countries work together more closely.

Perhaps most importantly, the V4 has influence in Brussels. Its successful advocacy on the EU's approach to migration, energy security, and regional infrastructure shows that the group can deliver results.

That is where the V4's leverage now lies, and what Magyar hopes to reinvigorate: the ability to build a common position in Brussels. Doing so will require sustained dialogue and realignment on topics such as the next MFF, support for Ukraine, and competitiveness, just to mention a few.

On the MFF, the countries will likely align in broad terms. All four want to preserve cohesion-type funding, which will disappear in its current form under the next MFF.

Ukraine will prove more complicated. Fico and Babis are unlikely to support financial aid, and their countries, in alignment with Hungary, are unlikely to actually contribute funds. Poland remains the only V4 country to support Ukraine, including financially. I expect tough discussions among the leaders as they try to agree on the scope and scale of support for Ukraine. The same goes for Ukraine's accession to the EU.

On the green agenda, the Czechs—and likely the Slovaks—will be skeptical. Babis has a coalition partner whose legislative priority is to oppose the phasing out of the internal combustion engine. While Tusk and Magyar will take a more supportive view toward the green agenda, Magyar will probably remain cautious.

On competitiveness, all V4 countries want a more competitive Europe. But again, the challenge lies in how to achieve that goal. Brussels decides trade policy, while national governments have primary responsibility for investment-related issues, which limits the need for all four countries to act together. The partners can still coordinate their positions and learn from one another—that know-how is not to be undervalued—but the tangible gains in this area will be limited.

A proposed expansion of the grouping remains unlikely

Magyar wants to involve Austria and Hungary's other neighbors. Romania, Croatia, and Slovenia appear to be natural partners. All face similar economic and fiscal pressures, as well as security threats from Russia.

But the more members, the harder it becomes to align views. That challenge will continue to hinder any formal expansion of the V4 and will likely keep discussions on a V4+ basis, shaped by convenience.

The V4 could be more—but won't be

The most the V4 could realistically achieve—and, as I am learning from the Hungarians, what it aims to do—is to coordinate positions in the European Council and lobby for its preferred outcomes.

The group, however, could and should be more.

The V4's geopolitical location has placed its members at the center of attention since the start of the war in Ukraine. Arguably, the war could have created momentum for the region, but that opportunity never materialized. Beyond the expected debates over strengthening NATO's eastern flank, the region did not emerge as a strong voice. Poland did. This was a missed opportunity for the region.

The countries could have supported Ukraine's democratic transition and served as a model as Kyiv navigates the complex enlargement process. They also could have spoken more forcefully within the EU, NATO, and other international forums on security issues.

They never did.

Simply put, the V4's current informal framework does not compel its members to do what they are not inclined to do. For that, the V4 would need a more institutionalized, supranational structure that pushes the leaders to work together even when their political interests diverge or their attention shifts elsewhere.

But there is no political will to build that kind of cooperation.

The V4 will therefore remain what it is, with its advances and setbacks. There will be joint statements, such as its condemnation of Russia's invasion of Crimea. Its members will coordinate their positions in Brussels and lobby in the European Council. There will be moments when the four countries discover that their interests genuinely align and moments when they find that they do not.

The V4 will be no more, and no less — at least for now.

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